

Peril and volatility for state budget

Trump’s tariffs and threats of defunding pose extra challenges for California. There’s ‘so much uncertainty.’

By TARYN LUNA

SACRAMENTO — As the stock market plummeted last week, California Assembly Speaker Robert Rivas sat at his desk in the state Capitol and predicted that President Trump’s tariffs would “squeeze our economy at every level.”

“This is certainly going to be the most challenging of years when it comes to our budget that I’ve had in my time in the Legislature. There will be some tough choices ahead,” the Democrat from Hollister forewarned. “But again, it’s so difficult to navigate this issue at the moment because of so much uncertainty. Every day is different.”

Less than 48 hours later, Trump paused most of the tariffs he imposed on imported goods. The financial markets that California’s progressive tax structure is dependent on shot up in response before bouncing up and down the rest of the week.

The whiplash underscores the challenge before lawmakers and Gov. Gavin Newsom this spring as they attempt to develop a state budget plan for the year ahead that funds schools, healthcare, roadways and other essential services.

Every state budget is built on forecasts of state and federal economic conditions that will affect tax revenues over the next 12 months. California’s over-size reliance on income tax from the top 1% of its earners, whose fortunes are often tied to the rewards they reap from the stock market, leaves the state particularly vulnerable to the booms and busts of Wall Street.

Trump’s erratic trade policies and threats to withhold federal funds from California, including public health allocations and support for schools, have made predicting revenue even more precarious than usual.

The tariffs and in-kind retaliation from other countries would undoubtedly hurt California, such as new surcharges on almond exports and deflating Silicon [See Budget, A7]



JONATHAN NEWTON Getty Images

REINTRODUCING grizzlies to California would require moving some from places such as Yellowstone National Park. Above, a bear drinks from Pelican Creek at the park with her cubs close by in June 2024.

Exploring a grizzly comeback

The California native bears could thrive once again if returned, a study says. Whether that’s a good idea may lead to a wild debate.

By LILA SEIDMAN

Grizzly bears are extinct in California but still show up everywhere you look.

The golden bruins emblazon the state flag and seal, live on in cartoonish effigy as university mascots, and roll off the tip of the tongue in place names like Grizzly Flats and Big Bear Lake.

But what if the real ursine deal could be brought back?

A new study indicates that they can be — roughly 1,180 of them — and Southern California mountains are among prime potential habitat for the apex predators. Whether they *should* be is a question for 40 million Californians and their policymakers.

The state’s official animal inspires

awe and holds cultural significance for tribes, and researchers note that they pose low statistical danger. But some wildlife officials say reintroducing grizzlies — which can weigh up to 1,000 pounds and run 35 mph for short bursts — would lead to increased conflict between humans and bears. An estimated 60,000 black bears roam the state, and property [See Grizzly, A8]

Overtime at Sheriff’s Department surges

Amid vacancies and more work, totals rise to 4.3 million hours and \$458 million in 2023-24. Union leader, outsiders express concerns.

By KERI BLAKINGER

The Los Angeles County Sheriff’s Department spent \$458 million on overtime during the last fiscal year, a ballooning figure that department officials say is driven by rising vacancy rates, increasing labor costs and expanding responsibilities.

County data show that the number of new deputies hired each year plummeted during the COVID-19 pandemic and has not fully recovered. At the same time, the number of deputies leaving the department rose, only returning to pre-pandemic levels last year.

With more people leaving the department than joining it, by March, 1,461 of the agency’s roughly 10,000 deputy jobs sat empty, and an additional 900-plus were held by people out on leave. Those who remain are left to pick up the slack, sheriff’s officials say, some working

dozens of hours of forced overtime each month. Last year, department data show, deputies worked more than 4.3 million hours of overtime.

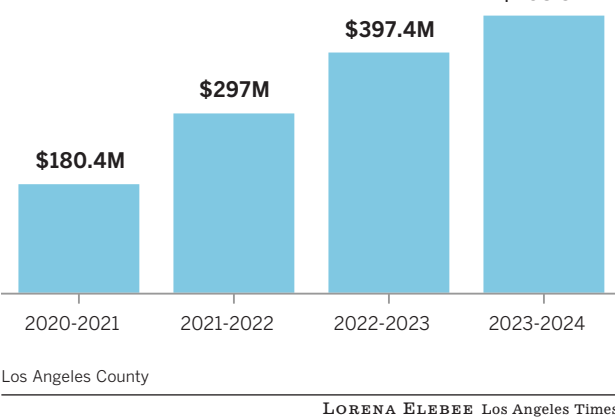
“I cannot tell you how proud I am of our employees stepping up to the plate,” Sheriff Robert Luna told The Times in a recent interview. “This is not on them. They are literally doing the work of thousands of more employees who are not available.”

Richard Pippin, president of the Assn. of Los Angeles Deputy Sheriffs, the union that represents rank-and-file deputies, worried about the effect on public safety.

“In 35 years, I’ve never seen things this bad. Deputy morale is at rock bottom due to all the forced overtime,” he told The Times. “Operations, training, and recruitment are all suffering due to this crisis. Anyone who has ever had to call 911 knows what short staffing can [See Deputies, A11]

Extra hours, extra pay

Overtime at the Sheriff’s Department by fiscal year (in millions)



Elsinore fault has been quiet, but it can unleash devastation

It’s no San Andreas, but the rift nearest the one tied to Monday’s quake has the potential for a 7.8.

By RONG-GONG LIN II

Below California’s famed beaches, mountains and metropolitan areas lies a sinister web of earthquake faults — some so infamous that their names are burned into the state’s collective consciousness.

There is, of course, the mighty San Andreas, whose massive slip caused the great 1906 San Francisco earthquake and whose notoriety has sparked multiple movies, video games, books, T-shirts and collectibles.

Also well known in L.A. is the Newport-Inglewood fault, which unleashed the 1933 Long Beach earthquake — the deadliest temblor in Southern California’s modern history.

The large earthquake fault close to the one that moved Monday morning in the mountains of San Diego County, however, is comparatively obscure. But the Elsinore fault is part of a larger seismic zone that ex- [See Elsinore, A8]



DENIS POROY Associated Press

TRACY TURNER, owner of Wynola Junction Antiques & Collectibles, looks over pictures that fell from their shelves when a magnitude 5.2 earthquake hit Monday near Julian, Calif.

Danger didn’t vanish with the flames

Altadena residents who tested surviving houses find lead at troubling levels.

By NOAH HAGGERTY

On Jan. 7, two residents on opposite sides of Altadena — Francois Tissot, a Caltech professor who studies the geology of ancient Earth and our solar system, living on the east side of town; and Jane Potelle, an environmental advocate living on the west side — fled the intensifying red glow of the devastating Eaton fire.

The inferno devoured home after home, unleashing what experts estimate to be tons of dangerous metals and compounds, from lead to asbestos to the carcinogen benzene. Carried through the vicious winds, the toxic substances embedded deep into the soil, seeped into the blood of first responders and leaked into structures in the area that hadn’t burned down.

Within weeks, Altadena residents whose homes had withstood the fire began to return — yet few were testing for contaminants both Tissot and Potelle knew were almost certainly sitting in their still-standing houses.

Working independently, they both decided to create a comprehensive picture of the contamination lurking within surviving homes, both in the burn area and miles outside it.

They came to similar results: In the houses inside the burn zone, there was lead — a metal capable of dealing irreversible damage to the brain and nervous system — at levels far exceeding 100 times the Environmental Protection Agency’s allowable limits. Tissot’s group also found lead levels exceeding the limit over five miles from the fire’s perimeter.

“Children exposed to lead will have diminished cognitive development,” said Tissot, referencing studies that found exposure [See Lead, A7]

Mental health care for babies

Children’s Hospital L.A. expands a program that addresses a crucial but overlooked need. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

New venues for L.A. Olympics

Dodger Stadium and Alamitos Beach are among the hosts for the 2028 Summer Games. **SPORTS, B10**

Tariffs crash TV’s ad party

Economic uncertainty could lead companies to reduce their spending on commercial time. **BUSINESS, A10**

Weather

Low clouds clearing. L.A. Basin: 67/53. **B6**

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